

Underspecified Valence and Goal Sensitivity in Predicates of Personal Taste

Víctor Carranza Pinedo

University of Münster

Valence Asymmetries Seminar – UPF

28 April 2026

The phenomenon



Camila G

Vina del Mar, Chile • 35 contributions



0



Modernity and excellent cuisine

Sep 2025 • Family

A modern Mood, which is reflected in every corner of Sutorito Maketto.

That Wednesday, 17/9, dinner was incredibly tasty and well achieved. Fried chicken baos to repeat without a doubt. Refreshing and generous cocktails. And Mila's attention was pleasant, always attentive to all our requests. It made our night incredibly pleasant.

We will definitely return.



“Dinner was
incredibly **tasty** and
well achieved”

Also the phenomenon?



MAJ



Interesting (in a bad way)

Review of **Casa California Medellin**



Reviewed Nov 9, 2021  via mobile

It's was a mistake for me. 2 days was enough. If you enjoy a loud mouth, know it all American who curses every other word, this is the place for you. Plenty of drugs everywhere and even more garbage spewing out of his mouth. It should be called Casa de Coke & bad Weed. My advice, pay a bit more and stay in the flatlands. The hills are dangerous, the higher you go the worst. Typical old American owner who thinks he's better than everyone around him. Clearly he is here because he thinks he can outsmart everyone and enjoys the nose candy. Everything about his place is cheap.

[More](#)

Date of stay: March 2021

[See all 2 reviews](#)

Claims

- A. Recent theories of PPTs (*tasty, boring*) focus on explaining the inferences PPTs trigger (e.g., acquaintance inferences) but neglect their **valence profiles**.
- B. A theory of PPTs that accounts for valence should, however, consider that:
 - Not all PPTs lexically encode a fixed valence (*interesting, intense*).
 - Positive and negative PPTs are not simply mirror images of one another.
- C. These differences are better captured by drawing on appraisal theories of affect.

- I. The explanandum
- II. Two recent accounts of PPTs
- III. Towards a new proposal
 - I. Distinguishing valenced from neutral PPTs
 - II. Understanding valence asymmetries

- I. The explanandum
- II. Two recent accounts of PPTs
- III. Towards a new proposal
 - I. Distinguishing valenced from neutral PPTs
 - II. Understanding valence asymmetries

PPTs

Moral & aesthetic predicates are standardly treated as **evaluative**:

- “Tormenting the cat is **wrong**.”
- “The sunset was **beautiful**.”

Predicates of personal taste (PPTs) are often grouped with them (Lasersohn, 2005; Stephenson, 2007; Umbach, 2021):

- “Red wine is tasty.”
- “Biographical movies are boring.”
- “Boardgames are fun.”
- “Rollercoasters are frightening.”

PPTs as evaluative

PPTs are often seen as **evaluative** because disagreements involving them are treated as clashes of evaluations, not facts (Kölbel, 2004; Marques, 2015)

- John: Hawaian pizza is **tasty**.
Mary: No, it isn't.
- John: Hawaian pizza is **gluten free**.
Mary: No, it is not.

The many senses of “evaluative”

(Soria-Ruiz, Cepollaro, & Stojanovic 2021)

A. Broad sense: gradable/multidimensional predicates like *healthy, intelligent* or *bold*.

B. Narrow sense: subjective, value-based predicates such as *tasty, boring, or frightening*

Note: both classes can give rise to faultless disagreements (Fleisher, 2013; Umbach, 2014).

- We need more diagnostics for subjectivity.

Standard diagnostics for subjectivity

(Sæbø, 2009; Bylinina, 2017; Umbach, 2021)

- ***To/for experiencer phrases***
 - Red wine is tasty to me/for me
 - The painting is beautiful to me/for me
 - ??Hawaiian pizza is gluten free to me/for me.
- ***Find-embedding***
 - I find this wine tasty.
 - I find this painting beautiful.
 - ??I find this wine gluten free.

The diagnostics are helpful, but they should be used with care
(Stojanovic & Kaiser, 2022)

A sharper diagnostic?

In plain assertions with PPTs, the speaker is taken to have first-hand experience of the object (Ninan, 2014):

- “The wine is expensive” $\nRightarrow$ The speaker has tasted it.
- “This machine is intelligent” $\nRightarrow$ The speaker has used it.
- “The wine is tasty” $\Rightarrow$ The speaker has tasted it.
- “The movie is boring” $\Rightarrow$ The speaker has watched it.

Acquaintance is a sharper marker of paradigmatic PPTs, though its extension beyond PPTs remains debated.

The inference is robust, but defeasible

(Pearson, 2013; Ninan, 2014; Anand & Korotkova, 2018)

The inference projects under negation:

- “The movie is **not** boring” $\Rightarrow$ The speaker has watched it.

But it can be “obviated”/cancelled in some environments:

- “**I’ve heard** the crème brûlée is tasty.”
 - “The crème brûlée **must** be tasty.”
 - “The crème brûlée **may** be tasty.”
-
- So a theory of PPTs must explain this complex pattern.

- I. The explanandum
- II. Two expressivist explanations**
- III. Towards a new proposal
 - I. Including neutral PPTs in the picture
 - II. Understanding valence asymmetries

Franzén (2020): an expressivist strategy

Step 1: Moore-like infelicity as a clue for expression

- ??“It is raining, but I do not believe it”
 - infelicitious because ordinary assertions express **beliefs**.
- ??“Ice cream is tasty, but I do not find it tasty”
 - infelicitious because evaluative assertions express **find-states**.

Step 2: Find-states are affective

They are states tied to **felt** experience, like liking or appreciating.
This would explain acquaintance inferences.

Franzén: an expressivist strategy

Step 3: A Gibbard-style semantics (Gibbard, 2003)

- Sentences denote sets of ordered pairs $\langle w, h \rangle$:
 - w = possible world
 - h = hypersensibility

A hypersensibility determines, for each world, what counts as tasty, beautiful, wrong, etc.

- $\llbracket \text{This ice cream is tasty} \rrbracket = \{ \langle w, h \rangle : \text{this ice cream is classified as tasty in } w \text{ by } h \}$

Some issues

A. Both PPTs and moral predicates are associated to affective states, but only PPTs trigger acquaintance inferences.

- Murder is wrong $\nRightarrow$ speaker is personally acquainted with murder

B. Coarse affective states like liking or detesting do not seem to require first-hand experience.

- I may like/detest a city I never visited.

C. No explanation of why acquaintance projects in negated cases, but is obviated under some operators.

Willer and Kennedy (2022)

Step 1: Assertions have grounding conditions.

To assert a proposition, the speaker must be in a state rich enough to distinguish p -worlds from $\neg p$ -worlds.

These conditions are specified by the predicates used:

- “The sky is **blue**” – grounded on **doxastic attitudes**. $\text{DOX}(a, w)$
- “Ice cream is **tasty**” – grounded on **experiential attitudes**. $\text{EXP}(a, w)$
- “Murder is **wrong**” – grounded on **normative attitudes**. $\text{NORM}(a, w)$

Willer and Kennedy (2022)

Step 2: Distinguish grounding from truth-conditions

For PPTs like *tasty*:

- Truth-conditions are ordinary: $\llbracket \textit{tasty} \rrbracket(x)$ maps x to the set of worlds where *tasty* is true of x .
- But come with lexical rules specifying **experiential** grounding conditions: $\text{EXP}(a, w) \triangleright \llbracket \textit{tasty} \rrbracket(x)$

Step 3: Explain acquaintance inference for PPTs

- Experiential grounding requires first-hand experience
- Doxastic and normative grounding don't have such requirement.

Projection and cancellation

Projection: negation targets only the at-issue content

- “Sea urchin is tasty”
- “Sea urchin is not tasty”
 - ⇒ The speaker has tried sea urchin

Both assertions still require the speaker to distinguish p -worlds from $\neg p$ -worlds for the same predicate.

Cancellation: some operators shift the default grounding conditions

- “Apparently, sea urchin is tasty”
 - ⇒ The speaker has tried sea urchin

Why? In these cases, the relevant grounding is provided by the operator.

What about valence?

If PPTs like *tasty* and ordinary predicates like *gluten-free* are similar w.r.t. truth-conditions, where is **valence** specified?

Note: Valence cannot be located at the level of grounding

- Assume “This ice cream is tasty” were something like “the speaker must be in a **positive** experience rich enough to distinguish p -worlds from $\neg p$ -worlds.”
- Then “This ice cream is not tasty” would inherit the same grounding.

Thus, we may locate valence in the lexical content of the predicate.

- I. The explanandum
- II. Two expressivist explanations
- III. Towards a new proposal**
 - I. Including neutral PPTs in the picture
 - II. Understanding valence asymmetries

The task

We need a theory that not only explains acquaintance inference, but also the role of valence.

Two facts regarding valence should be accommodated:

I. There are PPTs underspecified w.r.t. valence
(*surprising, intense, simple*)

II. Valence is not symmetrical
(e.g. “not disgusting” does not entail “tasty”)

- I. The explanandum
- II. Two expressivist explanations
- III. Towards a new proposal
 - I. Including neutral PPTs in the picture
 - II. Understanding valence asymmetries

Neutral PPTs

Stojanovic & Kaiser (2022): many PPTs are **underspecified** w.r.t. valence:

- “The film was *intense*.”
- “The match was *surprising*.”
- “The task was *simple*.”

These terms both from valenced PPTs like *fun*, and from middling predicates like *average* or *ordinary*, which locate objects near the **middle of a scale**.

Diagnostics

We can distinguish neutral from valenced PPTs as follows:

- **The Attitude Compatibility Test (S&K):**
 - “The film was intense and I like it.”
 - “The film was intense and I don’t like it.”
 - ?? **“This game is fun and I don’t like it.”**
 - ?? **“This game is boring and I like it.”**

Diagnostics

- **The GOOD/BAD WAY Test (S&K):**
 - “This film is surprising in a good way.”
 - “This film is surprising in a bad way.”
 - “This film is surprising in a good and bad way.”

 - ?? **“This game is fun in a good way.”**
 - ?? **“This game is fun in a bad way.”**
 - ?? **“This game is boring in a good way.”**
 - ?? **“This game is boring in a bad way.”**

Acquaintance inferences

Acq. Inf. suggest neutral PPTs are genuine PPTs (Solt, 2018).

- ?? “The lecture is interesting, but I have never attended it.”
- ?? “The concert is intense, but I have never been to it.”
- “The software is intelligent, but I have never used it.”
- “The neighbourhood is expensive, but I have never lived there.”

Neutral PPTs show that acquaintance and value are separated.

Task: explain why PPTs require experience, while allowing the value component to be fixed in some cases and open in others.

Towards a proposal

- Like Willer and Kennedy (2022), I distinguish truth-conditions from experiential grounding.
- My proposal enriches the truth-conditional side:
 - **PPTs classify objects by locating them in an appraisal space made available by experience.**
- The basic idea is:
 - grounding answers: what kind of access must the speaker have?
 - truth conditions answer: what region of appraisal space does the predicate pick out?

Affective attitudes

Attitudes like surprise, sadness, happiness, or anger are elicited by appraising objects (Scherer, 1984; Lazarus, 1991).

Affective experience begins with **goal relevance**: the stimulus must matter enough to trigger an affective state.

Once this condition is met, attitudes are distinguished along:

- Goal-congruence (*gc*) $\gg$ the basis for valence.
- Novelty (*nov*)
- Control (*con*)
- Agency (*ag*)

Appraisal profiles

For a speaker s in world w , let the appraisal profile of x be:

$$App_{s,w}(x) = \langle gc_{s,w}(x), nov_{s,w}(x), con_{s,w}(x), ag_{s,w}(x), \dots \rangle$$

A goal-relevant experience of x gives access to the appraisal profile $App_{s,w}(x)$.

Each PPT P picks out a region R_P in the set of possible appraisal profiles.

Grounding

Goal-relevance is a grounding condition across PPTs

- An assertion of $P(x)$ is felicitous only if the speaker has had a goal-relevant experience of x rich enough to determine whether x falls in the region associated with P .

For a context c , with speaker s_c and world w_c :

Assertable_c($P(x)$) only if $GR_{s_c, w_c}(x)$ is rich enough to settle whether $App_{s_c, w_c}(x) \in R_P$,

where $GR_{s_c, w_c}(x)$ is the speaker's goal-relevant experience of x in c .

Truth-conditions

Each PPT P picks out a region of this appraisal space:

$$\llbracket P \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = \mathbf{1} \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \in R_P,$$

where R_P is the region associated with P

Neutral PPTs

Neutral PPTs pick out different regions:

- $\llbracket \textit{surprising} \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = \mathbf{1} \Leftrightarrow \textit{App}_{s,w}(x) \in R_{\textit{surprising}}$
- $\llbracket \textit{intense} \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = \mathbf{1} \Leftrightarrow \textit{App}_{s,w}(x) \in R_{\textit{intense}}$
- $\llbracket \textit{interesting} \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = \mathbf{1} \Leftrightarrow \textit{App}_{s,w}(x) \in R_{\textit{interesting}}$

For all neutral PPT P , the region is compatible with both sides of goal-congruence:

- $\exists \alpha \in R_P [gc(\alpha) \geq \theta^+] \text{ and } \exists \beta \in R_P [gc(\beta) \leq \theta^-]$

Valenced PPTs

Valenced PPTs lexically constraint goal-congruence:

- $\llbracket \text{tasty} \rrbracket_{s,w}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{1} \Leftrightarrow \text{App}_{s,w}(\mathbf{x}) \in R_{\text{tasty}},$
 - where R_{tasty} contains only goal-congruent profiles
 - That is, $\forall \alpha \in R_{\text{tasty}} [gc(\alpha) \geq \theta^+]$
- $\llbracket \text{boring} \rrbracket_{s,w}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{1} \Leftrightarrow \text{App}_{s,w}(\mathbf{x}) \in R_{\text{boring}},$
 - where R_{boring} contains only goal-incongruent profiles
 - That is, $\forall \alpha \in R_{\text{boring}} [gc(\alpha) \leq \theta^-]$

So valenced PPTs differ in which region they lexicalise, while sharing a fixed orientation with respect to goal-congruence.

Negation and projection

For any PPT P , such as *tasty*

- $\llbracket \textit{tasty} \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = \mathbf{1} \iff \textit{App}_{s,w}(x) \in R_{\textit{tasty}}$

Negation reverses only the at-issue membership claim

- $\llbracket \neg \textit{tasty} \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = \mathbf{1} \iff \textit{App}_{s,w}(x) \notin R_{\textit{tasty}}$

But the grounding condition is unchanged.

So acquaintance inference's projects under negation.

This theory is not expressivist (in the classic sense):

- PPTs retain ordinary at-issue content: they classify objects by locating them in a region of appraisal space.

Neutral vs valenced PPTs differ in how their regions are structured:

- Neutral PPTs do not lexically fix the sign of goal-congruence.
- Valenced PPTs do.

Open questions:

- finer structure of the appraisal space
- domain-specific goal-congruence (e.g. gustatory, affective, aesthetic)

- I. The explanandum
- II. Two expressivist explanations
- III. Towards a new proposal
 - I. Including neutral PPTs in the picture
 - II. Understanding valence asymmetries

Valence asymmetries

Positive and negative evaluations are not interpreted symmetrically

- In language, this appears as negative strengthening:
 - “not good” is readily heard as “bad”;
 - “not bad” is much less readily heard as “good”.(Colston. 1999; Mazzearella, 2021; Gotzner 2024)

Related asymmetries appear more broadly in cognition and moral judgement (Pizarro, Uhlmann, & Salovey, 2003).

Two main explanatory families:

- Negative information attracts more attention / stronger processing.
- Negative space has more informational richness.

Valence asymmetry with PPTs

The asymmetry concerns the range of strengthened readings available under negation (Mazzarella, 2021; Gotzner, 2024)

“not tasty” may be understood as either

- negative (“bad”, “disgusting”)
- or neutral (“okay”)

while “not boring”

- neutral / mildly positive at best
- but does not straightforwardly mean “fun”

So negation does not mirror the two poles symmetrically.

How can we deal with this phenomenon?

Affective asymmetries

Negative emotions are often finely differentiated :

- anger: goal-incongruent, relatively high certainty, other-agency / blame
- fear: goal-incongruent, high uncertainty, low control
- sadness: goal-incongruent, low control, loss-oriented profile

By contrast, positive emotions (joy, happiness, etc.) are somewhat less differentiated (Ellsworth & Smith, 1988; Cavanaugh et al., 2007).

Asymmetries with emotion predicates

Negated positive emotion terms are more readily strengthened:

- “I am not happy” often suggests feeling sad / unhappy

Negated negative terms are weaker:

- “I am not sad” does not readily suggest feeling happy

Why? Because “I am not sad” remains compatible with other non-positive states (angry, frustrated, anxious, bored).

Towards an explanation

Hypothesis: the asymmetry comes from the fact that negative PPTs lexicalise more specific regions than positive PPTs.

On the one hand, positive PPTs lexicalise **broad** goal-congruent regions:

- $\llbracket tasty \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \in R_{tasty}$,
 - where R_{tasty} contains only goal-congruent profiles
 - That is: $\forall \alpha \in R_{tasty} [gc(\alpha) \geq \theta^+]$
- $\llbracket fun \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \in R_{fun}$,
 - where R_{fun} contains only goal-congruent profiles
 - That is: $\forall \alpha \in R_{fun} [gc(\alpha) \geq \theta^+]$

Negation of positive PPTs

Negation targets only at-issue region membership

- $\llbracket \neg P \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \iff App_{s,w}(x) \notin R_P$

If positive PPTs lexicalise broad positive regions, then negation tends to exclude the whole positive region:

- $\llbracket tasty \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \iff App_{s,w}(x) \in R_{tasty}$
- $\llbracket \neg tasty \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \iff App_{s,w}(x) \notin R_{tasty}$

This yields neutral and negative readings.

On the other hand, negative PPTs pick out narrow negative regions:

- $\llbracket boring \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \in R_{boring}$,
 - where R_{boring} contains goal-incongruent, **low novelty profiles**
 - That is, $\forall \alpha \in R_{boring} [gc(\alpha) \leq \theta^- \wedge nov(\alpha) \leq \theta^-]$
- $\llbracket frightening \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \in R_{frightening}$
 - where $R_{frightening}$ contains goal-incongruent, **low control profiles**
 - That is, $\forall \alpha \in R_{frightening} [gc(\alpha) \leq \theta^- \wedge con(\alpha) \leq \theta^-]$

Negation of negative PPTs

A negative PPTs lexicalise narrower negative regions:

- $\llbracket boring \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \in R_{boring}$,
- where R_{boring} contains goal-incongruent, **low novelty** profiles

Then, negation only excludes **that** particular negative region:

- $\llbracket \neg boring \rrbracket_{s,w}(x) = 1 \Leftrightarrow App_{s,w}(x) \notin R_{boring}$
- Is still compatible with $App_{s,w}(x)$ containing goal-incongruent, **high novelty** profiles.

So x may still be goal-incongruent, just not in the specific way picked out by *boring*.

Summary

- Work on PPTs has mainly focused on acquaintance inferences.
 - However, a satisfactory theory must also explain valence.
- Valence is not lexicalized in all PPTs and, when it is, its linguistic behavior display asymmetries.
- I have suggested that these facts can be captured by combining:
 - W&K-style experiential grounding, and
 - an appraisal-based account of PPTs' denotation.

Thank you

<https://carranza-pinedo.github.io>
carranzapinedovictor@gmail.com